

The Second Noble Truth — The Cause of Unsatisfactoriness

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So I'd like to say a few words about the second noble truth now, which is the truth of the cause of suffering. And in the Buddha's words, what is the noble truth of the origin of suffering? It is craving which renews being and is accompanied by relish and lust, relishing this and that. In other words, craving for sensual desires, craving for being, craving for non-being. But where does this craving arise and flourish? Wherever there is that which seems lovable and gratifying, thereon it arises and flourishes. There is this noble truth of the origin of suffering. Such was the vision inside wisdom, knowing and light that arose in me about things not heard before. And this noble truth must be penetrated by abandoning the origin of suffering.

So we have three sources of suffering that the Buddha describes there. One is sense pleasures. So all the lovely sights and sounds here in the countryside, good food. And then remembering that sense pleasures also includes all the pleasures of the mind, good conversations, good discussions, a detective story if you like detective stories, any sort of happy thoughts. And of course, the opposite is implied there. If we like the pleasant stuff, we also then want to get rid of the unpleasant stuff. So pain, irritating noises, unpleasant tastes and smells and so on. And of course, all the unhappiness of the mind, depression and fear and unhappy thoughts of all descriptions.

Craving is the word used in that particular sutta. Often it's called desire. Desire for sense pleasures. Sometimes called lust, lust for sense pleasures. So craving, desire, lust, that wanting. You could describe it as wanting what's lovely, not wanting what's horrible. There's also this secondary one, that craving to be.

So that's a craving to be somebody. We want to be, for example, recognised. We want to be valued. We want to be respected. So all of those make us feel good. They really give us a boost in our life. And we can get these around family, for example, if we're identified with our family. For example, the role as a parent can give a lot of joy and pride and happiness. And it can make the hard work involved in being a parent worthwhile. It can make sense of life. There's a role in life. There's a meaning to my life. I am a father or a mother, for example. So that can provide great joy in life. And these are real joys. The Buddha doesn't in any way say don't enjoy life. There's a list of the various happinesses, and one of them would be looking after family, looking after family and friends, looking after children, cherishing children.

Another area where we identify would be our jobs. So there again, we can really crave that sense of recognition around being somebody with a skill, being somebody with a trade, somebody who belongs to

some organisation, somebody with some expertise. So all of that, the craving to be an expert, to be a really good whatever it is, carpenter, plumber, whatever it is. Our hobbies as well. We want to be the best gardener, the best bridge player and so on. So this is all the area of craving to be, and it would include friendships, for example, to be a friend, to have friends.

So that gives us a lot of comfort. It helps our sense of self-worth. And again, this can be used very skillfully along the spiritual path. But it's just to see where we are also allowing it to draw us into suffering. That real neediness for maybe our friends to always be available, for example, or a terrible anxiety about our friends because we can't live without them. So all these desires can be used skillfully to support us along the path.

It's another huge desire, of course, the desire to be enlightened. That can really get in our way here. And Chögyam Trungpa, the Tibetan Buddhist master, he would call that spiritual materialism, that we're getting our status out of spiritual matters, maybe instead of houses and homes and stuff like that, but we're getting our sense of self-worth from spiritual progress. That can be an area which can cause huge suffering as well. So it's just to be aware of it. So they're all the craving to be. And you can probably think of many, many more examples.

And then there's the craving not to be. So that'll be all the areas that we don't want to be identified with. For example, failure. Most of us would dread the thought of being seen as the failure. So we tend to hide our mistakes, gloss over our mistakes, even pretend to ourselves that we didn't make them somehow or other.

And Joseph Goldstein just has a nice story around that. In one of his interviews with his teacher, Upan Dita, he was, without really having made a decision to report his practice as a tiny little bit better than it was, he just realised afterwards he was doing that. He had a sense of what he should be seeing at this stage of his meditation practice after so many years and so on and how equanimous he should be and how many insights he should have. So that was colouring the way he was reporting everything. And just at the end of the interview, Upan Dita said, "That's not true."

At the end of a nice, long, embroidered, flowing interview of lots of spiritual success. That's not true. So Joseph Goldstein just said he wanted the floor to open up and take him in. He was so embarrassed. It was terrible. So he spent days just struggling with embarrassment and self-judgment of all descriptions. And realising, as soon as it was said, he realised he'd been exaggerating.

Anyway, at the end of about two days of pure agony, he was able to just see, okay, the mind does this as well. That's another aspect of the human mind. We want to be a success. And that's what it does. It pretends that it's a little bit better than it is. So he was able to see himself more humorously from then on. So it was, in that sense, a very good lesson for him. So he never took himself quite so seriously after that, because the human mind plays all kinds of tricks. It really is very devious.

So we don't want to be a failure. Also the whole area of employment. It's often our first question: what do you do? When we meet someone, what do you do? So to have to say well I'm unemployed, that's a bit of a come down. In certain social circles, then, to be a janitor is a come down. So you just don't want to have to say all of that. So the whole area of employment, we might really be embarrassed about our employment or our lack of employment. And that can become a big source of stress for us, not wanting to be seen in certain social lights.

So there is really so much stress built into the human condition, wanting to be a success, not wanting to be a failure, wanting to be accepted. And not to blame ourselves for all of this. We can again hear the second noble truth, desire is the cause of suffering, and then start blaming ourselves for having all these desires. It's a very easy mistake for us to make and it's a mistake I find myself in again and again. So I find it helpful instead to reflect on the whole condition and to generate some compassion around it.

So all of these desires would be part of our survival strategy. And again, this probably comes from our evolution, just as we were mentioning before, that in order to survive, we need to thrive. We need the good stuff in life so we can thrive on things like good food, good education, a safe space as a home, maybe with a nice garden in the countryside or something like that. So all those pleasant sounds, pleasant sights, a sense of good social status, the good food, all of that, the safety, all of that would allow us to thrive. So naturally, our self wants to thrive. So those desires are built in to our system. It's not that they're our fault, or that we're wrong for having desires. They're essentially survival strategies. So in that sense, they are wise. So all of those that promote health and well-being, a sense of confidence, a sense of self-worth. So certainly not to be despised.

So to generate compassion around that whole area of desire, just to keep reflecting desires are natural. And a lot of them can be used for good, as we were mentioning before. It's a question of deciding which ones to follow and which ones not to follow.

So there is this teaching desire causes *dukkha*. There is maybe the tendency then to judge desire is wrong and to suppress it. But that is just another desire. That's the desire for enlightenment. The suppression of desire in order to get to the end of suffering. So that's a vicious circle. It can't work. It's an easy mistake, but we just have to see it again and again and keep dropping it.

But what can we do? So what the Buddha says is this noble truth must be penetrated by abandoning the origin of suffering. So we have to abandon our, often we use the word, let go of desire. So we can acknowledge the desire. And especially here in meditation, we don't have to fulfil our desires, but we can just really acknowledge them, feel them if possible. So that way we're not suppressing, we're allowing the desire just to express itself in our minds and our bodies, but we're not indulging it. So it's the middle way between suppression and indulgence.

And if we feel the desire to rush, the Mahāsi technique asks us to do everything slowly and we just feel really the desire to just rush through that door. And then can we feel that desire and feel the way it

propels our body forward and instead just see, can we relax, take it easy, open the door slowly. So that's, again, allowing the desire, the impatience for getting here, there and everywhere, that desire to burn out.

We have the desire to gobble our dinner, just get through it quick. And again, if we can just feel that desire, acknowledge it, so not make ourselves wrong for it, but just acknowledge it and let it be felt in the body as maybe the shoulders wanting to move, the hands wanting to move in order to get the next spoonful in, the jaws wanting to chew quickly, everything like that. Just notice all of the tension associated with that desire and yet slowing down, relaxing as best we can and not following the desire. So again, that's just letting the desire burn itself out. So that's our middle path, our work here.

And we can also just listen to our thoughts. "I want another biscuit." It's so easy to come in and say, dismiss that, that's a stupid thought, and we can just put it away. But if we listen to it, okay, I do want another biscuit, and allow it to be felt, really listen to it. So it's a kinder way of being with desire to really listen to those thoughts and realise that's what's happening. There is a desire. You might even feel somewhere in the body that is grasping itself around that thought of another biscuit.

"I want to go to bed." So again, just listening to that, really listening into it, feeling the wish to go to bed with interest in the feeling. We're taking off the interest in going to bed, that dream of how lovely bed will be, but instead it's the interest in the here and now, the feeling of wanting to go to bed. So listening attentively to our own desires rather than quickly answering them with a put-down of some form, allowing ourselves to be human, to have all these desires.

Of course, then there is the whole area of suppression of desire. We can't just stop that either. We can't just turn off the suppressive forces within us. They're probably very deep habits. So again, it's a question of listening to those as best we can. And that can be hard. Well, I find it anyway, quite hard. So the suppressive forces would often involve a very stern crossness somewhere. So just tuning in to where in my body is stern or cross. And for me, I find it in the forehead. And sometimes, yes, sometimes around the back of the neck, the jaws, all of that. So all of that is trying to almost clamp down on these desires for more biscuits or wanting to go to bed.

So to tune in to the suppressive forces as well, and again, listen to them, the quick giving out, the quick answer back to any desire like "I want a biscuit." And it says, "No, you don't. You've had enough." Just to notice those little quick reactionary thoughts and maybe feel into them. So that's listening and acknowledging to the control freak in us, which is a strong force within us.

And linked to that there can be a lot of shame, shame at our own imperfections, hating imperfections. Again, it'll be linked to probably fear of failure, fear of judgment, all of that. So they're going deep within us and they need a lot of tender acknowledgement, a lot of compassion, a lot of sympathy. So it's a long and patient process, really, being with this human condition that has so many desires built into it.

It's very interesting that there are so many different desires and they're often in conflict with one another.

The desire for the biscuit and then immediately, no, you don't want a biscuit. And other desires like we want to be liked by everybody, but we also want to have our own way.

Thanissaro Bhikkhu, he has a whole series on selves and not self, he calls it. It's a wonderful little series. If you remember, each desire, as we were saying last night, each desire has the effect that our whole being goes into this idea of self. An idea of self is born in order to fulfil the desire. So every desire brings up some other aspect of ourselves, some other aspect of our personality. So it can be the little whingy child who wants another biscuit, or it can be the stern schoolteacher who's saying, "No, you've had enough."

So he likens our condition as we're like a committee. We're not a person. We're a committee. And we're a committee at loggerheads with one another, one member shouting at the other. And often a lot is going on under the scenes. We're not very honest because we actually don't know ourselves that well. There's an awful lot of subconscious poking of ourselves going on here. So it's not even a committee, it's more like a corrupt town council, he says, where people are taking bribes from each other and stabbing each other in the back and so on. So we really have a bit of a job with all these conflicting desires and somehow trying to survive in the midst of all of this is no joke.

Now, one other possibility we have here is to see the detail of the arising of desire. So desire is born from either pleasant or unpleasant feeling. And the feeling then, if you remember, is just the recognition of some sense impression as being pleasant or unpleasant. So we smell the food, for example, at dinner. And so that's a pleasant aroma. And that would lead to the desire, "Okay, I want to get stuck into this now." And then the self is created in order to just get stuck in, to pick up the spoon and shove it into our mouth and get going on eating it.

So if we can notice all of that, the aroma and then the sudden way the system is ready to eat, the tension in the muscles ready to pick up knives and forks and so on. So if we can see that and just stop, just let it go, just stop, don't act on the desire and let it all die away. And instead what you'll have at some stage, a little bit later when the system has relaxed, will be again the pleasant aroma. And can you stay at that level of a pleasant aroma?

If we practice it, the desire then is just letting itself burn out. And if we can stay at that level of just pleasant *vedanā*, life is so peaceful. We don't have the urgency of desire. We don't have the stress of a self being created to fulfil them all.

The Buddha says this is really how we let suffering die away—we stay at the level of sense contact and *vedanā*, of knowing our sense impressions, knowing whether they're pleasant or unpleasant, but allowing desires to fade away. And they do burn away. So it's really for us to see that desires do burn. They do just fade away. If we don't indulge them, if we don't suppress them, they just burn away. It's very interesting.

Now, they come up again a second later, and you have to let that one burn away. So it's a patient process. But to see at least one, just that it dies away and I could be with this dinner even for a few moments with

just the pleasure and no stress, no need to hurry, just appreciating. That's an example of the peaceful life we could live and we will all live when we come to the end of suffering, when we abandon all our desires.

So I just want to leave this with the reminder that we don't have to judge ourselves wrong for having desires. We can use desires skillfully to get to the end of suffering. It's a conversation between Ānanda and somebody else. A Brahmin, anyway, is asking Ānanda, "What is the way to the end of suffering? For what purpose, Master Ānanda, is the holy life lived under the Buddha, the ascetic Gautama?"

"It is for the sake of abandoning desire, Brahmin, that the holy life is lived under the Blessed One."

"But, Master Ānanda, is there a path? Is there a way for the abandoning of this desire?"

"There is a path, Brahmin. There is a way for abandoning of this desire."

"But, Master Ānanda, what is the path? What is the way for abandoning of this desire?"

"Here, Brahmin, a bhikkhu develops the basis for spiritual power that possesses concentration due to desire and volitional formations of striving. He develops the basis for spiritual power that possesses concentration due to energy," and so on. He goes through a whole lot more of them. "This, Brahmin, is the path. This is the way for the abandoning of this desire."

So just notice that what Ānanda is saying, that we develop the basis for spiritual power due to desire. You know, we desire our spiritual progress. We use that desire to develop our spiritual powers. So it's a bit of a conundrum, isn't it? We're using desire to get to the end of desire. You know, we're striving to get to the end of striving.

So anyway, the Brahmin picks him up on this. He says, "Such being the case, Master Ānanda, the situation is interminable. It is impossible that one can abandon desire by means of desire itself."

And so Ānanda answers, "Well then, Brahmin, I'll question you about this matter. Answer as you see fit. What do you think, Brahmin? Did you earlier have the desire, 'I will go to the park'? And after he went to the park, did this corresponding desire subside?" He went to the park to meet Ānanda.

So the Brahmin answers, "Yes, sir."

"Did you already arouse energy thinking, 'I will go to the park'? And after he went to the park, did the corresponding energy subside?"

"Yes, sir."

And he goes through them all like that. He aroused volitional formations as well to go to the park. So he strove to go to the park. He desired to go to the park. He strove to go to the park. He got to the park. But then they all subsided.

So desires just subside after they've been fulfilled, or if we just watch them and let them burn out anyway. So we can therefore just let the desires we want to fulfil be fulfilled. Our desire is to meditate. We can act on those, we can allow those be fulfilled. Our desire to come and retreat, we can strive like mad to go and retreat. And that desire, that striving will just pass away when we go on to retreat.

So we don't have to be afraid of our desirous nature, you know, our striving nature, but we can use it in the right direction. So anyway, the Brahmin is eventually completely convinced. Ānanda asks him, "Well, what do you think now, Brahmin? Is the situation terminable or interminable?"

"Surely, Master Ānanda, such being the case, the situation is terminable, not interminable. Magnificent, Master Ānanda. From today, let Master Ānanda remember me as a lay follower who has gone for refuge for life."

So although desire is the cause of suffering, this is a gradual path and we use our desire to come to the end of suffering to get us to the end of suffering.

Thank you.

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